27

NANCY AND I LEARNED IN SACRAMENTO that one of the inevitable consequences of holding a prominent public office is a degree of personal risk. Death threats and security people become part of your life.

In 1968, after Robert F. Kennedy was assassinated on election night in Los Angeles, Secret Service details were sent from Washington to guard the governors of several states because of reports that foreign agents were plotting to kill other American officials. Shortly after the agents arrived in Sacramento, I had to make a trip to Los Angeles. While I was there, I was curious to see our old ranch near Lake Malibu again. I'd always enjoyed target shooting and while we were there in the wilderness, several of the agents and I decided to do some practice shooting. We set some tin cans up on a log and began firing away. While we were reloading, I mentioned an article I'd recently seen describing techniques for shooting from the hip and one of the agents said, "Oh yeah, we have to do that."

When it was my turn, I went into a low crouch, raised my gun, and shot from the hip.

I've always been a right hander but sometimes I think I was intended to be a southpaw because there are some things I just do automatically with my left hand—like shooting a gun.

Well, in any event, that afternoon I shot from the hip with my left hand, following the method described in the article, and missed the can by a mile. Then one of the Secret Service agents stepped up and pulled his gun from a holster and started shooting from the hip. But he didn't crouch: He